empowering the third tier of leadership at the taluk level. The Right to Information Act, Aadhaar ID cards and the Jan Dhan Yojana, which banked the 531 million unbanked, emerged as major enablers of transparency, financial inclusion and streamlining welfare programmes. The Goods & Services Tax (GST) in 2017 ended the taxing chaos that threatened to derail India's economic progress. The strides in India's economy, infrastructure and governance were matched by those in defence and space. We became the fourth nation after the US, Russia and China to acquire nuclear triad capability with the firing of Agni-1 ballistic missile in 1989 and the induction of INS *Arihant* in 2016. When we sent Chandrayaan-1 to the moon in 2008, our credentials as a serious spacefaring nation were firmly established.

Concurrently, tectonic turning points were bringing about tremendous change in the country's social consciousness. Women of the country, at the receiving end of sexual violence, earned some hard-won legislative respites. Among them the Vishaka Guidelines of 1997 that mandated protection of women at the workplace, and the stringent criminal law amendments enacted in 2013 after Nirbhaya, a young physiotherapy intern, was brutally gang-raped aboard a bus in the national capital. Law came to the rescue of the country's gay community as well, when the Supreme Court decriminalised homosexuality in 2018. Alongside, environmental consciousness grew too, courtesy movements such as the one to save the Silent Valley and the Chipko Andolan. In 2014, Narendra Modi embarked on the Swachh Bharat Abhiyaan, to erase the ignominy of open defecation in the country. It has profoundly changed our sanitary environment, helping us bring down crippling infant mortality due to diseases like cholera and typhoid.

Of course, nothing reinforces a nation's confidence like sporting success. Thus the uplifting World Cup win of 1983, and the IPL glory, making India cricket central. The past 49 years have also given us sporting legends that have inspired generations.











Sunil Gavaskar with his monumental tonnage became a role model for Sachin Tendulkar. Viswanathan Anand with his own grandmastery and his mentorship has unleashed what Garry Kasparov called 'the era of Vishy's children' upon the world of chess. One of them, 18-year-old Gukesh Dommaraju, is India's newest and youngest ever world champ. Abhinav Bindra, who shot to Olympic fame with India's first solo gold, prompting Neeraj Chopra to trace the same arc with a javelin throw. As for turning points in entertainment, the best of them came in the year INDIA TODAY was born: *Sholay*, 1975. A landmark blockbuster film, it entered the annals of cinema history by changing the very criteria of box-office success. The '80s belonged to *Hum Log*, when both the colour TV and the teleserial entered our drawing rooms. Outside, the world rocked to the sounds of Indipop, and a phenomenon called desi disco. Among our other cultural exports were godmen, starting with Rajneesh (Osho) in Oregon, who held a sway over the western mind like no other. Sushmita Sen and Aishwarya Rai conquered the world in more winsome ways, Indian art in more expensive fashion.

Through it all, INDIA TODAY was there. Covering cause as well as effect. In words and in images. We dip into our photo archives to bring you unusual visual flashbacks. Iron Ladies Indira Gandhi and Margaret Thatcher at a Festival of India event in 1982 that presaged many such events showcasing India to the world. N.R. Narayana Murthy and other Infosys founders in their early years, confabulating to start an IT revolution. Vijay Mallya promising 'good times' and ushering in the pub culture; a flamboyant M.F. Husain painting a horse on a horse, bringing global attention to contemporary Indian art; a young Salman Rushdie clutching his Booker-winning *Midnight's Children*, heralding the arrival of Indian writing in English. A half-century of recording Indian reality as it unfolded. This special issue is a montage of those years. A happy way to finish INDIA TODAY's roaring 40s!

(Aroon Purie)